

PROTECT YOURSELF FROM OCCUPATIONAL STRESS

Experiencing pressure and demands at work is normal. However if these demands exceed knowledge and skills and challenge your ability to cope, occupational stress can occur.

Arrange urgent assessment for to the health worker with occupational stress and any of:

- Alcohol or drug intoxication at work
- Aggressive or violent behaviour at work
- Inappropriate behaviour at work
- Suicidal thoughts or behaviour

Adopt measures to reduce your risk of occupational stress



Protect yourself

Look after your health:

- Get enough sleep.
- Exercise, eat sensibly, minimise alcohol and avoid smoking.
- Address your general health and get screened for chronic conditions.

Look after your chronic condition if you have one:

- Adhere to your treatment and your appointments.
- Avoid diagnosing and treating yourself.
- If you can, confide in a trusted colleague/manager.

Manage stress:

- Delegate tasks as appropriate; develop coping strategies.
- Talk to someone (friend, psychologist, mentor), or access helpline ☎ 178.
- Take time to do a relaxing breathing exercise each day.
- Find a fun or creative activity to do.
- Spend time with supportive family or friends.

Have healthy work habits:

- Manage your time sensibly.
- Take scheduled breaks.
- Remind yourself of your purpose as a clinician.
- Be sure you are clear about your role and responsibilities.

Protect your team

Decide on an approved way of behaving at work:

- Communicate effectively with your patients and colleagues ☎ 176.
- Treat colleagues and patients with respect.
- Support each other. Consider setting up a staff support group.
- Instead of complaining, rather focus on finding solutions to problems.

Cope with stressful events

- Develop procedures to deal with events like complaints, harassment/bullying, accidents/mistakes, violence or death of patient or staff member.

Look at how to make the job less stressful:

- Examine the team's workload to see if it can be better streamlined.
- Identify what needs to be changed to make the job easier and frustrations fewer: equipment, drug supply, training, space, décor in work environment
- Discuss each team member's role. Ensure each one has say in how s/he does his/her work.
- Support each other to develop skills to better perform your role.

Celebrate:

- Acknowledge the achievements of individuals and the team.
- Organise or participate in staff social events.

Identify occupational stress in yourself and your colleagues

Possible alcohol or drug problem

- In the past year, have you/colleague:
 - 1) drunk ≥ 4 drinks¹/session, 2) used illegal drugs or 3) misused prescription or over-the-counter medications? If yes to any substance misuse likely.
- Smells of alcohol

Change in mood

- Indifferent, tense, irritable or angry
- In the past month, have you/colleague:
 - 1) felt down, depressed, hopeless or 2) felt little interest or pleasure in doing things? If yes to either depression likely.

Recent distressing event

- Diagnosis of chronic condition
- Bereavement
- Needlestick injury
- Traumatic event

Poor attendance at work

- Frequent absenteeism
- Frequent lateness
- Often takes sick leave

Marked decline in work performance

- Reduced concentration
- Fatigue

The health worker with any of the above may have substance misuse, stress, depression/anxiety or burnout and would benefit from referral for assessment and follow-up.

¹One drink is 1 tot of spirits, or 1 small glass (125mL) of wine or 1 can/bottle (330mL) of beer.